

Confidentiality protects the contents

Confidentiality means restricting information to authorised people or systems. Encryption is one of its most important tools. When end-to-end encryption works as intended, message content is readable at the endpoints rather than by every intermediary carrying it.



Confidential communication is not necessarily anonymous communication. An observer may be unable to read a message yet still learn that one account contacted another at 11:42 p.m., how frequently they communicate, which devices were used or how much data travelled between them. This is metadata—data describing other data—and it can reveal relationships and routines even when the words remain protected.

Think of a sealed envelope. The letter is confidential, but the addresses, postmark and delivery route remain visible. Encryption seals the digital letter. Anonymity concerns whether the sender can be identified.

Pseudonymity creates a consistent alternate identity

A pseudonym is an identifier other than your real name. It may be a pen name, gaming handle, forum username or creator identity. Pseudonymity lets people build history and reputation without placing their legal name on every interaction.

It is fragile. A pseudonymous account becomes connected to you when you reuse a personal photograph, email address, telephone number, biography, payment method or distinctive username. Separate identifiers can also be linked through behaviour: posting at the same times, discussing the same workplace, repeating unusual phrases or following the same small group.

A legitimate pseudonym differs from impersonation. Calling yourself “MonsoonReader” creates a new identity. Using another real person’s name and photograph to deceive people appropriates an existing identity. Privacy does not require pretending to be somebody else, but actually taking the necessary precautions to not reveal too much unnecessarily.

Anonymity breaks the link to a person

Anonymity means that an observer cannot reliably determine which person performed an action within a relevant group. If a website knows one of ten visitors submitted a comment, anonymity is weaker than when the possible author could be one of ten million.

It also depends on the observer. A comment may be anonymous to readers but identifiable to the platform through login records or network information. It may be anonymous to the platform but recognisable to a colleague who knows the author’s story. Internet privacy guidance therefore treats anonymity, pseudonymity and unlinkability as related but distinct properties.

Perfect anonymity is difficult because identities leak through layers. A tool may conceal your IP address while your browser reveals a distinctive combination of screen size, fonts, language and settings. A fresh username may remain separate until you log into a personal account in the same session. Tor Browser is designed to hide a user’s real IP address and reduce tracking, yet the Tor Project warns that it cannot guarantee perfect anonymity.

Incognito Mode: What to know

Private or Incognito browsing mainly controls what remains on your device after the session. It can prevent the browser from saving local history and may isolate or delete session data when the window closes. It is useful on a shared computer or for temporarily opening another account.

It does not automatically hide activity from websites, an employer, a school, an internet service provider or organisations managing the network. Google and Mozilla state this directly in their browser documentation.

Classify before you trust

For any privacy feature or tool, perform this six-step check:

1. Write down what it hides: message content, local history, IP address, legal name or another identifier.
2. Identify who loses visibility: another device user, the website, network operator, service provider or public.
3. List what remains visible, including account details, metadata, payment information and behavioural clues.
4. Decide whether the identity is real, pseudonymous or genuinely unknown to the observer.
5. Check what happens after the session ends: deletion, retention, synchronisation or backup.
6. Ask what single mistake could reconnect the activity to you.

Apply the test to an Incognito tab, encrypted message, forum pseudonym and public Wi-Fi connection. The results will differ. Privacy is not a switch; it is a collection of properties, each protecting a different part of your digital life from a different observer. 